# Staph Infection from Commencement

## By Clay McLeod Chapman

*Sarah Havermeyer, forty-one*

For the rest of my life, I will be haunted by the horror and anguish my son caused. I cannot look at a child in a grocery store or on the street without thinking about how my son's schoolmates spent the last moments of their lives. My son changed everything I believed about myself, about God, about family, and about love. I think I believed that if I loved someone as deeply as I loved him, I would know if he were in trouble. My maternal instincts would keep him safe. But I didn't know. And my instincts weren't enough. And the fact that I never saw tragedy coming is still almost inconceivable to me.

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## INTRODUCTION

*The inspiration, if you want to call it that, of this selection was not the Columbine High School killings but the Virginia Tech massacre, one gunman, 32 dead, April 16, 2007, Blacksburg, Virginia. In that case, there was a lot of anger and resentment toward the mother of the shooter. How could she have not known? How could she not have seen this coming? How could she not have stopped it? In actual life we never hear about the parents of the killer, but in Staph Infection, from the play Commencement, by Clay McLeod Chapman we do.*

**SARAH:** They gave me my own waiting room. Hid me in the pediatric wing, far away from the other families. It's much quieter at this end of the hospital. Less hectic here. Less parents, less press. Spent the last hour simply listening to the hum of fluorescents over my head.

Went over to the window on a whim once, lured in by the camera flashes. The parking lot's all gone now. It's suddenly engulfed in a forest of transmission

antennas, budding up from the roofs of these news vans. The network call letters look like initials of young couples carved into the bark of each tree. KBCW-TV plus WGBO-4. WDBJ-7 hearts WSLS-10 4-eva . . . .

When Mitchell was much younger, he and a handful of kids from the neighborhood all went out into the woods behind our houses to play a game of hide-and-seek. When it was Mitchell's turn to be *it*, he leaned his head against his own tree just as everyone else had before him. Closed his eyes and counted to a hundred. By the time he turned back around, he found himself facing the woods all alone. *Ready or not, here I come* – echoing through the trees. But what Mitchell didn't realize – and why would he, really – was that everybody else had already run home by then. Didn't stop him from playing, though. Peeking behind each tree. Searching for his friends.

An hour went by before I was on the phone with the neighbors, asking if they knew where Mitchell was. But none of their kids would say, shrugging their shoulders. When there weren't any parents left to call, I took to the woods myself. Flashlight in hand. Finally found him leaning against a tree, huddled into himself. *Shivering*. Poor thing caught pneumonia that night. Had to take him to the hospital, waiting in this same room.

***SARAH:*** *Want to tell me what happened?*

***MITCHELL:*** *No.*

***SARAH:*** *We can keep it between you and me, if you'd like. Promise I won't tell.*

***MITCHELL:*** *I don't want to talk about it.*

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**SARAH:** There are never any magazines here. Nothing but coloring books flung across the floor. Crayons scattered all around, like shell casings discharged from a rifle. Every color of the rainbow falling to the floor, round after round after round . . .

Not that I feel like reading right now. Simply had that reflex to flip through something. Get my mind off things. Picked up a coloring book without even realizing what it was at first, skimming the pictures just to pass the time. Glancing at all the empty animals, empty cartoon characters. Page after page. Their blank bodies filled in with scribbles, crayon spread everywhere. No consideration for coloring in the lines, whatsoever. You'd think they'd all been shot, every animal hemorrhaging Crayola across the page. Their splatter pattern in *Razzle Dazzle Rose* or *Tickle Me Pink*.

The amount of times I've sat here over the years, waiting amongst all the other mothers – I've lost county by now. They blend together after a while. All the check-ups. The mumps. Flu shots. Chicken pox. Not to mention ear infections. A tonsillectomy. A sprained wrist. The list just goes on and on . . .

It's a wonder my son even reached high school.

How any of our children made it this far.

Not that the news is saying anything. Not until the police notify the next of kin. The reporters have been recycling the same information for hours now, the live coverage sounding stale already.

No names yet. Just numbers.

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Last time I had to wait this long, it was because Mitchell had swallowed something he shouldn't have. *Marbles*. Started complaining about his tummy aching at the dinner table, refusing to finish his macaroni – so the very next day, I brought him in for an X-ray. And sure enough, there they were – a constellation of bright white contrasting against that ghastly black of his stomach. The negative image of a half dozen glass pellets settled into his belly. A grape cluster tethered together in pale veins.

Benjamin Pendleton had put him up to it. Said he'd be his *best friend* if he swallowed the whole set, all ten marbles. And to think that Mitchell had almost made it, more than halfway there – determined to earn Benjamin Pendleton's approval, to win this position as his pal, *bestest friends*, only giving up once his throat constricted itself, his own esophagus refusing to swallow anymore, no matter how hard he tried, no matter how hard he forced himself to eat one more, *just one more*, begging with his own throat to let him injest just one last marble before stumbling back home, sick to his stomach. To *prove* his worth. As a *friend* to Benjamin.

***SARAH:*** *Want to tell me who put you up to this?*

***MITCHELL:*** *No.*

***SARAH:*** *Mitchell – you're only hurting yourself by not saying anything.*

***MITCHELL:*** *I don't want to talk about it.*

**SARAH:** The police have been ushering all the parents in through the rear entrance of the hospital, away from the camera crews. The second I saw Wendy Pendleton in the hallway, barely able to even stand on her own two feet – I knew why she was here. Recognized her right away, even though we hadn't

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spoken to each other in ages. Not since our sons were in the third grade together.

Her eyes had glazed over. Nothing but a pair of marbles settled into each socket, flickering under the fluorescents. Felt like I was staring at a teddy bear. Not some mother who'd just identified her son.

They've placed a police officer right outside my door. *For my protection*, they say. They're worried some wandering father might find me here, hiding amongst the stuffed animals. The jig saw puzzles. The coloring books with the mottled corners, their pages sticking together from all the constant gnawing. Seems as if children choose to chew through these books rather than read them. The edges are still wet, even after office hours have come and gone for the day. The pulp rubs right off between my fingers. I'm thinking of the poor puzzle with its missing pieces, all of them dissolving inside some sick kid's stomach. Nurses have to sanitize these toys at the end of every day, spraying them down with disinfectant. They have to kill off the bacteria before the following morning – before it starts up all over again. Once child will pass along their germs to whoever puts the same stuffed animal's filthy limb into their mouth next. They'll end up catching something completely different than whatever it was they walked in here with.

Seems fitting to be sitting here then. Almost like old times. Wouldn't be so surprised if a nurse were to walk in any minute now, calling out Mitchell's name – *The doctor will see you now.*

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But none of the nurses will even come near me now. Won't look me in the eye. Passing them all in the hallway, they'd simply bow their heads. Focus on the linoleum rather than face me. As if they were afraid? *Of me?*

The press is about to take my boy away from me. This is my last chance to have him all to myself, the way I want to remember him --- before I have to give him up. Let him go.

I'm imagining some reporter sifting through the yearbook, flipping from page to page just to find his photograph. Before long, Mitchell's face will be broadcast all over the news – which is unfortunate, since he never took his class pictures seriously. He'd never tell me what day they were being taken, just so I couldn't force him to dress up. Look nice for his picture. By the time I'd find out, it was always too late. They would've already snapped off the shot. If I ever wanted to order any photos for the rest of the family, I'd have to buy these wallet-sized prints of him in one of his ratty t-shirts. His hair all tussled. Refusing to smile for the camera.

Can't even bring myself to look at his yearbook now. Seeing him there, surrounded by the rest. Their faces clumped together, grinning all round him. Nothing but an obituary now – the whole yearbook. This grim assembly of smiles.

The world will weep for the children of Midlothian High – but no one will weep for mine. I'll have to cry for my child alone. You won't find his name amongst the others. HE's been omitted from the list of victims. Not that he was ever invited into their club anyways. Mitchell was never asked to play with the

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rest. They'll say it was my son who took their children away – but what none of these parents are willing to admit is that their sons and daughters took my child away from me long before today. Mitchell had the bruises to prove it. Half of our trips to the hospital were for fractures that magically happened on their own. Sprained wrists that mysteriously appeared out of nowhere, no explanation whatsoever. Black eyes that looked like black holes, swallowing up my son, the distance deepening within his gaze.

Every time, *every time* I've had to sit here in this room, I've lost a little bit more of my son. It was only a matter of time before there was nothing left of him to take back home.

***SARAH:*** *Can we talk?*

***MITCHELL:*** *. . . Why?*

***SARAH:*** *Want to tell me what's been on your mind lately?*

***MITCHELL:*** *No.*

***SARAH:*** *Anything happening at school?*

***MITCHELL:*** *No.*

***SARAH:*** *What about –*

***MITCHELL:*** *Mom.*

***SARAH:*** *Can't we just chat? Just for a minute?*

***MITCHELL:*** *There's nothing to talk about.*

***SARAH:*** *There's plenty.*

***MITCHELL:*** *Just let it go, mom.*

***SARAH:*** *Please, honey . . .*

***MITCHELL:*** *I said no. Just drop it, alright?*

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**SARAH:** All I want is to sit with the rest of the parents. I want to wait amongst the other mothers. To mourn with them. I've lost my child, too. Why can't I sit with them?

We deserve to wait together.

Found a stray puzzle piece at my feet, softened with some child's saliva. There's no telling what the picture's of. Has a fleshy complexion. Even feels like flesh, the cardboard all soaked in spit. Its interlocking tabs are so flimsy, they'll flap back and forth whenever I rub my fingers over them.

Came across another piece tucked just behind the leg of my chair. Same color, same wet texture. The two pieces fit together perfectly.

Suddenly the picture's coming into view. Here's a piece of his cheek. A tooth, A shard of his skull, a clump of his hair matted down in blood. Fragments of his face, the skin still adhered to the bone.

I'm picking up what's left of him off the floor. The hundreds of tessellating flecks of flesh and bone, blown off at close range. Passing the time working on this jigsaw puzzle of my son's face, just to get one last look at him. *High muzzle velocity.* When Mitchell was done, he slipped the gun over his tongue. The blast reached through the roof of his mouth. Ruptured all the soft tissue before bursting through the back of his skull, sending puzzle pieces all over the classroom wall.

Kids will put anything into their mouths.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

*Author: Clay McLeod Chapman*
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## AWARD HISTORY

*2011 National Qualifier*
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